

year's election, made him a towering figure and enabled YSR to appoint ministers at his personal choice.

He made it abundantly clear that his primary concern was the welfare of the poor and the farmers. "I am planning to make Andhra Pradesh the mainstay of the Congress," he told INDIA TODAY after assuming office a second time. It was towards this end that he embarked on a series of journeys to villages, the first on the day he died. A medical graduate, YSR learnt to feel the public pulse instantly and act on it. Yet, he occupied office only briefly—1980 to 1983—as a minister under the tutelage of three chief ministers to understand the nuances of governance until he became chief minister in 2004, the first from the Congress in three decades to complete a full five-year term and steer the party to electoral victory again in 2009.

By promising and living up to his word of providing power free of cost to farmers and take up more poor and farmer-friendly measures, he kept his rural constituency intact (see box). At the same time, he fostered the growth of industry and got plans cleared for starting more special economic zones in Andhra Pradesh than in any other state. That combination of rural populism and progressive industrialisation made him hugely popular in both rural and urban Andhra Pradesh.

The unmistakable stamp of his personality—he was a powerful friend

PROJECTS ON LINE

YSR relied on a slew of schemes to shore up his popularity

■ **Liberalised Public Distribution Scheme:** Under this, families below the poverty line are given 20 kg rice at Rs 3.50 per kg every month. Subsidised edible oil, red gram and cooking gas cylinder are also given.

■ **Pavala Vaddi:** A micro-finance scheme that enables women's self-help groups to get loans at 3 per cent.

■ **Arogyasri:** A health insurance cover in which up to Rs 2 lakh is reimbursed directly to the hospital by the state for treating those below the poverty line.

■ **Dial 104 Rural Mobile Health Units:** These vans offer health services to villages.

■ **Free Power to Farmers:** For nearly five years now, farmers are getting uninterrupted supply of electricity for free.

■ **Rajiv Udyogasri:** A plan to create 25 lakh jobs by 2013.

and an equally powerful foe—encouraged many to switch sides and join the Congress even as a large crop of budding young politicians were drawn towards his charismatic personality. It is this that helped him along with confident and long-time friend Dr KVP Ramachandra Rao to field a large number of new, young and winning aspirants in the legislative Assembly polls earlier this year without a murmur of protest from those who were denied tickets.

This personal trait has also made the Congress remain a cohesive force rather than be the fractured party driven by squabbling factions like in the past. And it made him a loyal, dependable and, perhaps, the most trustworthy lieutenant of the Congress President Sonia Gandhi with whom he enjoyed a rare one-on-one relationship till the very end.

As one who quickly became the "first among equals" of Congress chief ministers, heightened by the increase in the number of Congress MPs elected to the Lok Sabha from the state, YSR took the initiative in the state securing sizeable, at times more than proportionate, share of Central Government resources and allocations and made sure of its effective use. His hard line against a separate Telangana, or for the revival of the Legislative Council and a bi-cameral legislature, according 4 per cent reservation for Muslims, similarly reservation for Christians among Dalits and offering travel subsidy to Christians going on pilgrimage to Bethlehem like the Haj subsidy for Muslims may not have evoked widespread support. Some may have seemed controversial but he backed his beliefs and faced the odds, including the legal challenges to many of his schemes in courts.

Rarely have politicians evolved in a manner to contribute and leave an indelible mark on governance in a state even more so a large one such as Andhra Pradesh. And, at the same time, make an impact on his party as a satrap who delivered on his promises whatever the consequences. He was a confident leader, who while working for the party and the people, brooked no oppo-

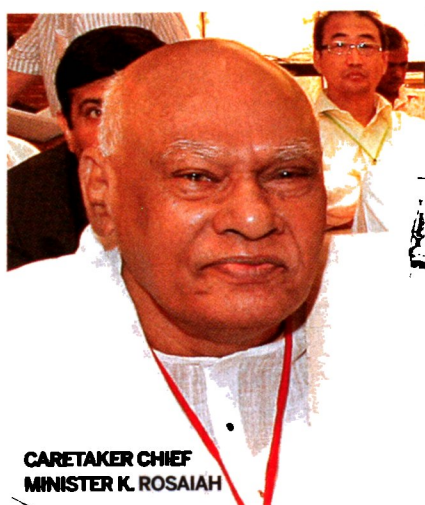
Succession Issue

With the Congress rudderless, the choice of his successor is crucial. The options are:

■ **Finance Minister K. Rosaiah, caretaker CM, is frontrunner given his seniority and stature.**

■ **Central Minister Jaipal Reddy, a veteran, takes over.**

■ **A younger leader is brought in mid-term.**



CARETAKER CHIEF
MINISTER K. ROSAIAH

SIPRA DAS